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Attorneys for Plaintiffs

IN THE UNITED STATES DISTRICT COURT
FOR THE DISTRICT OF MONTANA
MISSOULA DIVISION

FREE SPEECH COALITION, INC.; DEEP CONNECTION TECHNOLOGIES, INC.; CHARYN PFEUFFER; JFF PUBLICATIONS, LLC; ANNA LOUISE PETERSON; LYNSEY GRISWOLD; PHE, INC.; and CONVERGENCE HOLDINGS, INC.,

Plaintiffs,

v.

AUSTIN KNUDSEN, in his official capacity as the Attorney General of the State of Montana,

Case No. _____

COMPLAINT AND DEMAND FOR JURY TRIAL

Defendant.

Plaintiffs, for their Complaint, state and allege as follows:

INTRODUCTION

1. Despite numerous federal court decisions invalidating as unconstitutional state and federal laws seeking to regulate or ban the publication of material harmful to minors on the internet, the Montana legislature has tried yet again. S.B. 544 (the "Age Verification Act" or "Act") places substantial burdens on Plaintiff website operators, content creators, and countless others who use the internet by requiring websites to age-verify every internet user before providing access to non-obscene material that meets the State's murky definition of "material harmful to minors." Specifically, and in relevant part, the Act subjects to liability any "commercial entity that knowingly and intentionally publishes or distributes material harmful to minors on the internet from a website that contains a substantial portion of such material" where "the entity fails to perform reasonable age verification methods to verify the age of individuals attempting to access the material." That liability is owed to "an individual for damages resulting from a minor accessing the material, including court costs and reasonable attorney fees as ordered by the court"—making the Act enforceable, in the first instance, by private actors rather than government officials.

2. Pursuant to 18 U.S.C. § 2201 and 2202, and 42 U.S.C. § 1983 and 1988, this action seeks declaratory and injunctive relief to vindicate rights,

privileges, and immunities secured by the Constitution and laws of the United States. The Act violates the First and Fourteenth Amendments to, and the Commerce and Supremacy Clauses of, the United States Constitution, because it impermissibly burdens Plaintiffs' exercise of their rights thereunder in myriad ways.

3. The Act violates the First Amendment in several respects. First, it imposes a content-based burden on protected speech that requires narrow tailoring and use of the least restrictive means to serve a compelling state interest, yet it captures a substantial quantity of protected speech without accomplishing its stated purpose of protecting minors from materials they may easily obtain from other sources and via other means. Second, compelling providers of online content to place an age-verification content wall over their entire websites unconstitutionally labels them as "adult businesses," with all the negative implications and ramifications that follow. And third, by requiring the use of some particularized approval method as a condition to providing protected expression, the Act operates as a presumptively-unconstitutional prior restraint on speech.

4. The Act violates the Fourteenth Amendment in myriad ways, too. First, because it fails to provide a person of ordinary intelligence with fair notice of to whom the Act applies, what is required, and what is prohibited, the Act is impermissibly vague, violating the procedural component of the Due Process

Clause. Second, the Act intrudes upon fundamental liberty and privacy rights without being properly tailored to serve the government's interest, thus violating the substantive component of the Due Process Clause. Third, the Act's exemption of certain news organizations draws impermissible content-based distinctions among persons engaged in free speech, violating the Equal Protection Clause.

5. The Act also significantly burdens interstate commerce by restricting the ability of providers of online content to communicate with Montana residents. This burden is clearly excessive in comparison to the limited local benefit provided by the Act and the availability of less restrictive alternative means of protecting children from erotic content.

6. Finally, by treating website operators as the publishers of material hosted on their websites but produced by other content providers, the Act stands in direct conflict with 47 U.S.C. § 230 ("Section 230") and is therefore preempted by that supreme federal law.

7. This attempt to restrict access to online content is not novel. A quarter-century ago, the United States Supreme Court invalidated a federal law restricting internet communications deemed harmful to minors on First Amendment grounds in *Reno v. ACLU*, 521 U.S. 844 (1997). It did so just a few years later in *Ashcroft v. ACLU*, 542 U.S. 656 (2004). And in state after state, laws containing content-based

restrictions on internet communications deemed harmful to minors have been held unconstitutional.[1]

8. Despite this long legacy of constitutional invalidity, the Montana legislature enacted, and the governor signed into law, the Act in May 2023, rendering it effective on January 1, 2024. Now, providers (including Plaintiffs) are in the untenable position of abiding by its terms and enduring the constitutional infringement, or violating them and risking ruinous liability.

9. As such, Plaintiffs seek to have the Act declared unconstitutional and void, and to have the Attorney General enjoined from participating in its enforcement.

JURISDICTION AND VENUE

10. This case arises under the United States Constitution and the laws of the United States and presents a federal question within this Court's jurisdiction under Article III of the Constitution and 28 U.S.C. § 1331 and 28 U.S.C. §

[1] See, e.g., *American Booksellers Foundation v. Sullivan*, 799 F. Supp. 2d 1078 (D. Alaska 2011) (Alaska); *American Booksellers Foundation v. Coakley*, 2010 WL 4273802 (D. Mass. 2010) (Mass.); *PSINet, Inc. v. Chapman*, 362 F.3d 227 (4th Cir. 2004) (Virginia); *American Booksellers Foundation v. Dean*, 342 F.3d 96 (2d Cir. 2003) (Vermont); *Cyberspace Communications, Inc. v. Engler*, 238 F.3d 420 (6th Cir. 2000) (Michigan); *ACLU v. Johnson*, 194 F.3d 1149 (10th Cir. 1999) (New Mexico); *ACLU v. Goddard*, Civ. 00-0505 (D. Ariz. Aug. 11, 2004) (Arizona); *Southeast Booksellers Ass'n v. McMaster*, 282 F. Supp. 2d 389 (D.S.C. 2003) (South Carolina); *American Library Association v. Pataki*, 969 F. Supp. 160 (S.D.N.Y. 1997) (New York).

1343(3). It seeks remedies under 28 U.S.C. §§ 2201 and 2202, 42 U.S.C. §§ 1983 and 1988, and Fed. R. Civ. P. 65.

11. Venue is proper in this district under 28 U.S.C. § 1391(b) because a substantial part of the events giving rise to the claim occurred in this district.

PARTIES

I. Plaintiffs

12. Plaintiff Free Speech Coalition, Inc. (FSC) is a not-for-profit trade association incorporated under the laws of California with its principal place of business in Canoga Park, CA. FSC assists film makers, producers, distributors, wholesalers, retailers, internet providers, performers, and other creative artists located throughout North America in the exercise of their First Amendment rights and in the vigorous defense of those rights against censorship. Founded in 1991, the Free Speech Coalition currently represents hundreds of businesses and individuals involved in the production, distribution, sale, and presentation of constitutionally-protected and non-obscene materials that are disseminated to consenting adults via the internet. Most of that material would fit within Montana's statutory definition of "material harmful to minors."

13. The Free Speech Coalition sues on its own behalf and on behalf of its members to vindicate its own constitutional rights, its members' constitutional rights, and those of the members' respective owners, officers, employees, and

current and prospective readers, viewers, and customers. Both FSC and its members are harmed by the Act as detailed in this Complaint. The requested declaratory and injunctive relief will, in whole or in part, alleviate those harms.

14. Plaintiff Deep Connection Technologies Inc. (DCT) is a business corporation organized under the laws of Delaware with its principal place of business in San Francisco, CA. DCT operates O.school, a judgment-free online educational platform focused on sexual wellness. Andrea Barrica, O.school's founder and CEO, is a queer woman of color who has grown O.school to reach more than 25 million people globally and 4.2 million across the United States. O.school's mission is to help people worldwide improve their sexual health, power, and confidence. Previously, Barrica co-founded inDinero.com, the leading financial solution for growing startups, and served as a partner at 500 Startups, a global venture capital fund where she worked with hundreds of startup companies. Barrica was raised in a religious, conservative Filipino family that preached abstinence, and she received only fear-based sex education in public schools. Seeking support and information about sex and sexuality, Barrica was unable to find reliable resources online, leading her to launch O.school in 2017 in order to change the way people learn about sexuality. She is the author of *Sextech Revolution: The Future of Sexual Wellness*, and she is a professional speaker, having presented for TED Unplugged, SXSW, the Women in Tech Festival, UN

Women, Planned Parenthood, and others. Barrica fears that O.school contains a "substantial portion" of content that meets the statutory definition of "material harmful to minors."

15. As O.school provides critical sex education that it deems appropriate (and necessary) for older minors, DCT opposes any age-verification measure that would preclude those teens from accessing O.school's content. DCT is confused as to what constitutes "reasonable age verification methods" under the Act and concerned about the prohibitive cost of providing complying age verification protocols.

16. DCT is harmed by the Act as detailed in this Complaint. The requested declaratory and injunctive relief will, in whole or in part, alleviate those harms.

PRAYER FOR RELIEF

WHEREFORE, Plaintiffs respectfully request that the Court:

A. Permanently enjoin the Attorney General, his officers, agents, servants, employees, and attorneys, and those persons in active concert or participation with them who receive actual notice of the injunction, from participating in the enforcement of the Act;

B. Declare that the Act violates the First and Fourteenth Amendments to, and the Commerce and Supremacy Clauses of, the United States Constitution and is therefore unenforceable and void;

C. Award Plaintiffs their reasonable costs and attorneys' and other fees pursuant to 42 U.S.C. § 1988; and

D. Grant Plaintiffs such other and further relief as the Court deems just and proper.

DEMAND FOR JURY TRIAL

Plaintiffs hereby demand a trial by jury on all fact issues in the above-entitled case.

DATED: May 14, 2024

BOONE KARLBERG P.C.

/s/ Natasha Prinzing Jones
Natasha Prinzing Jones
Thomas J. Leonard
Attorneys for Plaintiffs